Divisions. Also, two BSF battalions comprising more than 2,000 personnel have been pulled out of anti-Naxal operations in Odisha and moved to the Samba sector in Jammu.

GAPS IN THE SYSTEM

In 2020, when China upped the ante at the Line of Actual Control in Ladakh, the army's RR moved two divisions from Reasi to Ladakh, weakening the counterinsurgency grid and troop density. "This caused a vacuum," according to a senior defence official, "and gave Pakistan a chance to push foreign terrorists into Rajouri and Poonch."

The dense jungles in the two districts soon became a holding ground to launch attacks against the army in Jammu, the first one happening in October 2021 in Poonch. Former Northern Army chief Lt Gen. Deependra Singh Hooda (retd) concedes that local support is essential in counter-insurgency operations. "The Jammu attacks are a deliberate attempt to stoke violence," he says. "They are trying to counter the government's claim of normalcy. It is a war of narratives. We have to strengthen our people outreach to defeat Pakistan's plans."

The claims of public disaffection are also not unfounded. The absence of an elected government since 2018 to address day-to-day civic issues has triggered much unease among the people. Taranjit Singh Tony, a District Development Council member from Suchetgarh village on the International Boundary, says they have to protest for even basic amenities such as power or water. "Even the recruitment drives conducted by the government are being questioned now," says Tony. "All these issues can be exploited by the militants...everyone in J&K is feeling cheated by the Centre and the BJP, but they don't understand it."

THE PAK CONNECTION

On July 27, three sketches of terrorists responsible for the attacks in Dessa (Doda) were released by the J&K Police, with a bounty of Rs 5 lakh each for

HOW JAMMU LOST ITS TERROR-FREE TAG



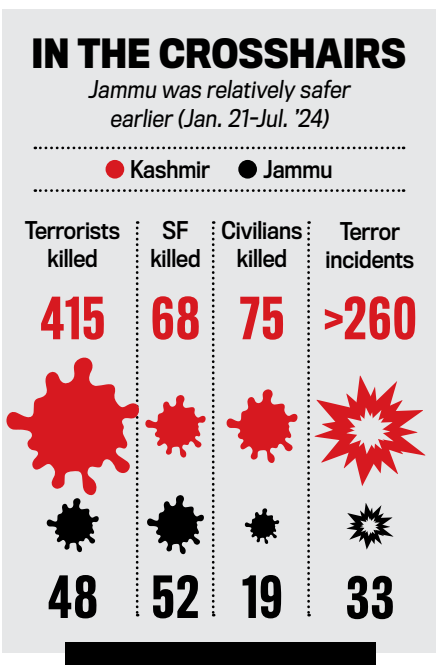
Unlike the Kashmir valley, which is largely flat, the topography of Jammu is hilly, covered with rugged mountains, hostile jungles interspersed with large habitations. The region is in close proximity to the porous LoC as well as the international border (IB) with Pakistan, compounding the security problems. The security establishment, including officers from the Indian Army and J&K police, cite the inhospitable terrain, besides low troop presence and lack of human intelligence for the renewed insurgency.

The current situation took seed in 2020 soon after the clashes with Chinese troops in Galwan along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh. Several companies of the army were shifted from the region to the China front, causing lapses in the security grid. The counterinsurgency grid in Jammu was anyway weak due to years of peace and calm after being declared 'militancy-free' some 15 years ago.

In 2019, after the abrogation of Article 370, the focus of the security grid was entirely on containing the protests and militancy-related incidents in the Valley. The direct

IN THE CROSSHAIRS

Jammu was relatively safer earlier (Jan. 21-Jul. '24)



SF: Security forces; Source: J&K Police

information. On the same day, the Indian Army foiled a suspected BAT (Border Action Team) attack from across the LoC in the Kupwara sector in the Valley where one soldier lost his life while four others, including a major, suffered injuries. A terrorist was also killed in the prolonged firefight but it has reinforced the idea of the involvement of Pakistan's SSG in the recent attacks. "These are not plain hit-and-runs. The military precision in the attacks has the SSG's signature written all over it," says a key official involved in the counter-insurgency operations. In fact, it is suspected that the dead intruder was an SSG commando.

Unconfirmed reports indicate that a 600-strong SSG battalion has crossed into the Kupwara region and fanned out from there. There are also reports of 50-60 ter-